



FIELDS OF FRANCE

When Shakespeare was growing up, he would often have seen oxen pulling plows in the fields around Stratford. In *Henry V*, he compares France to an unplowed field overgrown with weeds, with a plow rusting away.

Longhorn

A country childhood

WILLIAM SHAKESPEARE grew up in the heart of the countryside. He knew the farmers' fields around Stratford, the meadows where wildflowers grew, and the Forest of Arden to the north. As an adult writing plays in London, Shakespeare drew on his memories of the countryside. His plays are full of accurate descriptions of flowers, trees, wild birds and animals, clouds, and the changing seasons. In *Macbeth*, Shakespeare describes night falling with the words, "Light thickens, and the crow makes wing to the rooky wood," and in *Romeo and Juliet*, Capulet, hearing of his daughter's death, says, "Death lies on her like an untimely frost upon the sweetest flower in all the field."

LITTLE LIVESTOCK

Farm animals were smaller in Shakespeare's time than they are now. Some of today's rare breeds give us an idea of what they looked like. The Bagot goat has not changed since 1380, when King Richard II gave a herd to Sir John Bagot.

Livestock

In the 1500s, farm animals had many uses. Cattle were milked and used to pull plows. Sheep provided wool, meat, and milk. Goats were used for milk, meat, horn, and leather. In November, when most livestock was killed because animal feed was in short supply, pigs were fed on acorns in the woods, to provide a valuable source of fresh meat for the end of the winter.

*"When icicles
hang by the wall,
And Dick the shepherd
blows his nail,
And Tom bears logs
into the hall,
And milk comes frozen
home in pail ..."*

WILLIAM SHAKESPEARE
Winter in *Love's Labours Lost*

Bagot goat